Consumer insight study | Social listening, Nov 2025 to Oct 2026

Fieldnote Apparel · fictional client

What Gen Z and Millennial fast-fashion shoppers in the US and Canada say about the brands (fall 2026)

Public Reddit talk is a signal, not a measurement of shoppers. Within that limit, the Zara-led group of authors is the segment where Fieldnote's mid-priced, trend-led offer meets the most open dissatisfaction: Zara draws a higher share of negative sentences than Aritzia or Uniqlo, and Zara is discussed mostly for price and quality. Segments are weakly separated, so this is a hypothesis for the next study, not a verdict.

> Reader's note: two phrases in this summary are not fully backed by the charts, "mostly for price and quality" and "the most open dissatisfaction"; see Caveats on the evidence.

THE ANSWER IN ONE LINE

Fieldnote should enter next year with the Zara-led talk segment, positioned on trend and fit, and validate that choice with a survey first

29,507
Reddit items analysed
from 16,697 authors, Nov 2025 to Oct 2026

18.4%
of Zara's sentences are negative
n=392, 95% CI 14.8% to 22.5%; Uniqlo 7.5%

42.4%
of brand-naming replies name Uniqlo first
n=217 replies, 95% CI 36.0% to 49.0%; 48 of 60 threads are menswear

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Fieldnote should enter next year with the Zara-led talk segment, positioned on trend and fit, and validate that choice with a survey first

Situation

Fieldnote plans to grow in the US and Canada in 2027.

Complication

Core competitive set: Aritzia, Zara, H&M, Shein, Uniqlo. The market is also moving (external context from cited sources, not listening data): store closures, new US import rules and fast US growth at Aritzia.

Question

Which shopper segment to target first, and how to position against Aritzia, Zara and the rest of the competitive set.

Answer (a hypothesis to validate)

Target segment: Segment 1 (Zara-led, fit/sizing-minded; 83 authors, 15.8% of eligible authors, n=525, 95% CI 12.9% to 19.2%)

Takeaway 1, module 04

Shein is discussed more for sustainability and ethics, and Uniqlo more for style and trend, than the other brands

Takeaway 2, module 05

Shein and Zara draw more negative sentences than Aritzia, Uniqlo or H&M, but the tool understates negativity

Takeaway 3, module 06

Five talk groups emerge, but they overlap, and the Zara-led group is the suggested first target

Uniqlo named first

42.4%

n=217 brand-naming replies; 48 of 60 threads menswear

Authors who state an age

2.3%

33 of 1,453 brand-mentioning authors

Negative sentences, Zara vs Uniqlo

18.4% vs 7.5%

n=392 and n=504; the tool understates negativity

Segment 1 (Zara-led) share

15.8%

83 of 525 authors; 95% CI 12.9% to 19.2%

Silhouette at k=5

0.189

highest of k=2 to 6, still weak

VADER agreement with hand labels

64%

kappa 0.45, n=50, one labeller

Base: 29,507 Reddit items from 16,697 authors, 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31; 1,453 brand-mentioning authors, 2,100 single-brand sentences.

In plain words. VADER is an automatic positive/negative word scorer; kappa is agreement beyond chance; silhouette is how distinct the groups are, from 0 (not at all) to 1 (clearly separate).

SUMMARY

The board at a glance

Business question

Fieldnote plans to grow in the US and Canada in 2027. Leadership must decide:

1. Which shopper segment to target first.
2. How to position against Aritzia, Zara and the rest of the competitive set.
3. Which brand strengths to borrow and which competitor weaknesses to exploit.

Who we listened to

Public Reddit posts and comments, Nov 2025 to Oct 2026: 29,507 items from 16,697 authors; 1,453 of those authors mention a brand. Also App Store store-level ratings (review text could not be collected) and Wikipedia page views. This is social listening, not a survey.

Target segment

15.8%

Target segment: Segment 1 (Zara-led, fit/sizing-minded; 83 authors, 15.8% of eligible authors, n=525, 95% CI 12.9% to 19.2%)

3 key findings

45 vs 22

Shein talk about sustainability and ethics: sentences found vs about 22 expected

exact expected count: 21.6

23.6%

of Shein's sentences are negative

n=356 sentences; 95% CI 19.5% to 28.3%; VADER understates negativity

2.3%

of brand-mentioning authors state an age

33 of 1,453 authors; 95% CI 1.6% to 3.2%

Watch-outs

- Social media is not a representative sample of North American Gen Z and Millennial shoppers; Reddit is self-selected, and who posts there is not measured in this data.
- 48 of the 60 recommendation threads are menswear, so top-of-mind results lean to menswear-friendly brands.
- VADER agreement with hand labels is moderate (64%, n=50, 95% CI 50.1% to 75.9%) and it understates negativity.
- Segments are weak (low silhouette) and describe talk patterns, not shopper types.

In plain words. VADER is an automatic positive/negative word scorer; silhouette is how distinct the groups are, from 0 (not at all) to 1 (clearly separate).

Next step

A fielded survey on a representative sample of Gen Z and Millennial shoppers in the US and Canada, to validate awareness, ownership, profile, attribute ratings and the size of the Zara-led segment. Pricing tests, ad creative and product concepts remain out of scope.

MARKET CONTEXT

What is changing around the five brands

External context from the cited sources, for interpretation only. None of these figures comes from the listening data.

EXTERNAL CONTEXT, NOT LISTENING DATA

Forever 21 closed all its US stores in 2025 and now sells in the US online and through wholesale only; in Canada it is run separately.

Source: FashionUnited, 2025-09-18; Retail Insider, 2025-03-17

EXTERNAL CONTEXT, NOT LISTENING DATA

Hudson's Bay closed all its stores by June 2025; it is no longer a Canadian channel.

Source: Global News, 2025-06

EXTERNAL CONTEXT, NOT LISTENING DATA

The US suspended the de minimis exemption for all countries on Aug 29 2025; Shein's US revenue fell 14.3% in Q1 2026. Canada kept its low-value import thresholds, and Canadian use of Temu and Shein rose in 2026.

Source: Troutman, 2026-08-18; Retail Gazette, 2026-07-27; Retail Insider, 2026-03-12

EXTERNAL CONTEXT, NOT LISTENING DATA

Aritzia's US revenue grew 60.3% in Q2 FY27 and is now two-thirds of its total.

Source: Aritzia results via newswire.ca, 2026-10-08

EXTERNAL CONTEXT, NOT LISTENING DATA

eBay completed its purchase of Depop on Jul 30 2026.

Source: TechCrunch, 2026

METHOD IN BRIEF

Who we listened to

Evidence is social listening, not a survey. Full method, definitions and formulas are in the appendix.

29,507
Reddit items

16,697
authors

60
recommendation threads

12
months, Nov 2025 to Oct 2026

Reddit

9,987 posts and 19,520 comments, collected through the Arctic Shift archive. 1,453 authors mention a brand; 2,100 single-brand sentences feed sentiment and positioning.

App Store

Store-level US ratings only (all-time, not a sample): Aritzia 4.91, Zara 4.82, H&M 4.84, Shein 4.73, Uniqlo 4.78. Review text could not be collected.

Wikipedia

Monthly English page views for the five core brands, used only as a descriptive trend.

Main caveats

- Social media is not a representative sample of North American Gen Z and Millennial shoppers; Reddit is self-selected, and who posts there is not measured in this data.
- 48 of the 60 recommendation threads are menswear, so top-of-mind results lean to menswear-friendly brands.
- Top-of-mind, penetration and positioning are proxies, not survey measures.
- VADER agreement with hand labels is moderate (64%, n=50, 95% CI 50.1% to 75.9%) and it understates negativity.

Chapter A

Brand health: who is top of mind and who converts

This chapter answers: Which brands do people name first when asked where to shop? Who says they bought or own each brand?

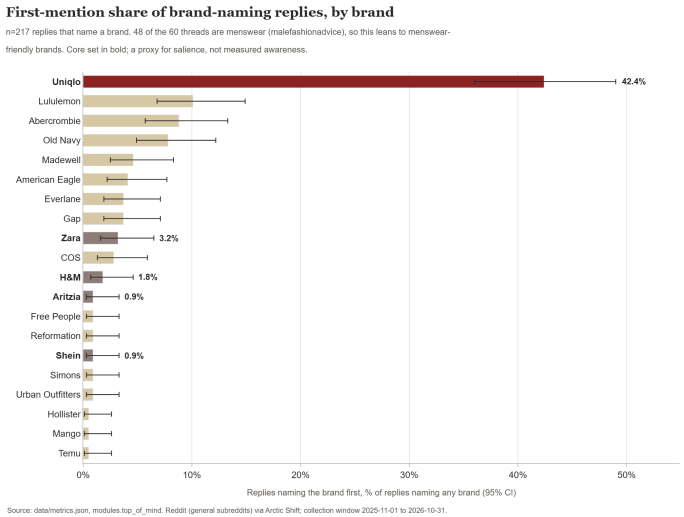
MODULE 01 · TOP-OF-MIND

01 Uniqlo is named first in recommendation threads far more often than the other four core brands, but the sample leans to menswear

U	Z	H&M	A	S
Uniqlo	Zara	H&M	Aritzia	Shein
42.4%	3.2%	1.8%	0.9%	0.9%
named first	named first	named first	named first	named first
n=217, 95% CI 36.0% to 49.0%	n=217, 95% CI 1.6% to 6.5%	n=217, 95% CI 0.7% to 4.6%	n=217, 95% CI 0.3% to 3.3%	n=217, 95% CI 0.3% to 3.3%

42.4%
of brand-naming replies name Uniqlo first
n=217 replies; 95% CI 36.0% to 49.0%

WHAT WE FOUND



THE QUESTION
Which brands do people name first when asked where to shop?

THE DECISION
Which competitors Fieldnote must displace in the shopper's first thought, and which it can treat as secondary.

SO WHAT
In this sample only Uniqlo stands apart from the other four, whose intervals overlap. Because most threads are menswear, the result reflects menswear-friendly brands and says little about Gen Z or Millennial women.

WHAT FIELDNOTE SHOULD DO
Fieldnote should not read this module as a ranking of the womenswear market, and should add an aided and unaided awareness question to the validating survey before setting any awareness target.

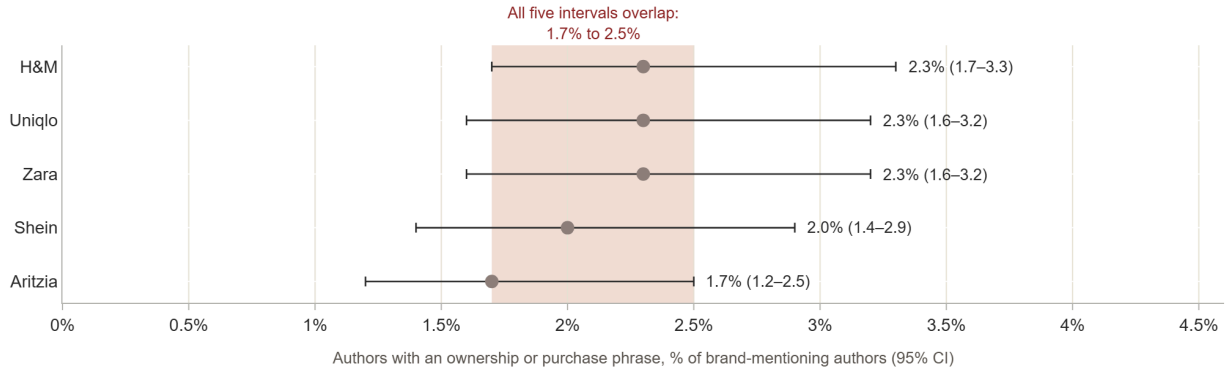
MODULE 02 · PENETRATION

02 Self-reported purchase talk is similar across the five brands, with overlapping intervals

WHAT WE FOUND

Penetration proxy: authors with an ownership or purchase phrase

n=1453 authors who mentioned any brand. A proxy: phrase matching, not confirmed buyers; the shaded band is the range every interval shares.



Source: data/metrics.json, modules.penetration_proxy. Reddit (general subreddits) via Arctic Shift; collection window 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31.

1.7% to 2.5%

the range all five brands' ownership-talk intervals share

n=1,453 authors who mentioned a brand; each brand's own 95% CI is wider

THE QUESTION

Who says they bought or own each brand?

THE DECISION

Whether Fieldnote is entering a market where one brand already holds most ownership talk.

SO WHAT

The values are small by construction and the five intervals overlap, so this data does not separate the brands on ownership.

WHAT FIELDNOTE SHOULD DO

Fieldnote should not claim a penetration gap against any competitor from this data and should measure claimed ownership in the survey.

SUPPLEMENTARY, NOT AUDITED

ADDED AFTER THE AUDITED KEEPLOOP CYCLE; NOT PART OF REPORT.MD

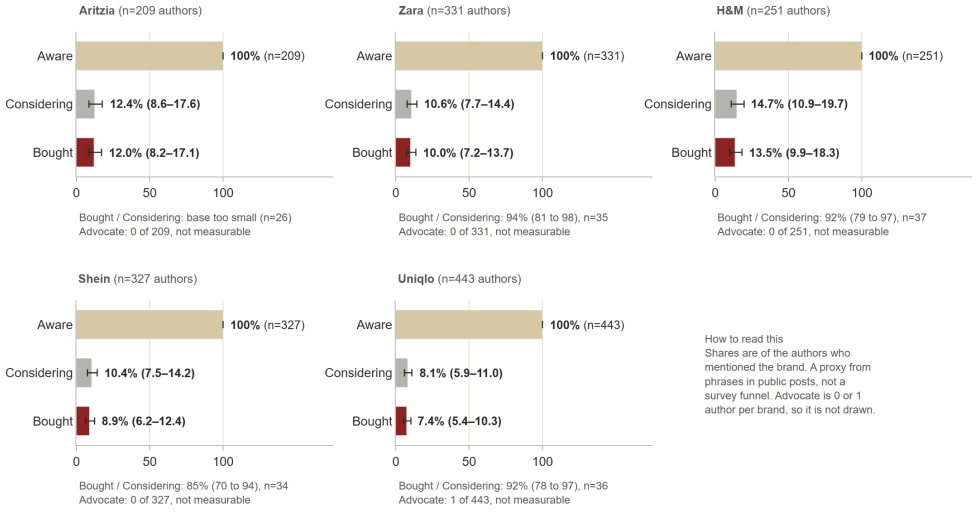
WHAT WE FOUND

Between 7% and 14% of the authors who mention each core brand also say they bought it; Advocate is too thin to measure

Brand funnel (proxy). Social-listening proxy, not a survey funnel: shares of the authors who mentioned each brand.

Considering is almost the same as Bought, because most Considering authors qualified through a purchase phrase.

Advocate is 0 or 1 author per brand, so it is not measurable.



Source: data/metrics.json, supplementary.funnel.by_brand. Reddit (general subreddits) via Arctic Shift; supplementary analysis, not audited; collection window 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31.

What the chart shows

Among authors who mentioned each core brand, 8.1% to 14.7% also used a considering phrase and 7.4% to 13.5% a purchase phrase. Where the step has at least 30 authors, 85% to 94% of Considering authors are also Bought.

Read with care

Advocate is 0 or 1 author per brand, so it is not measurable and not drawn. Considering is almost the same as Bought, because most Considering authors qualified through a purchase phrase. Aritzia's Considering to Bought step is base too small. These are phrase counts in public posts, not survey funnel rates.

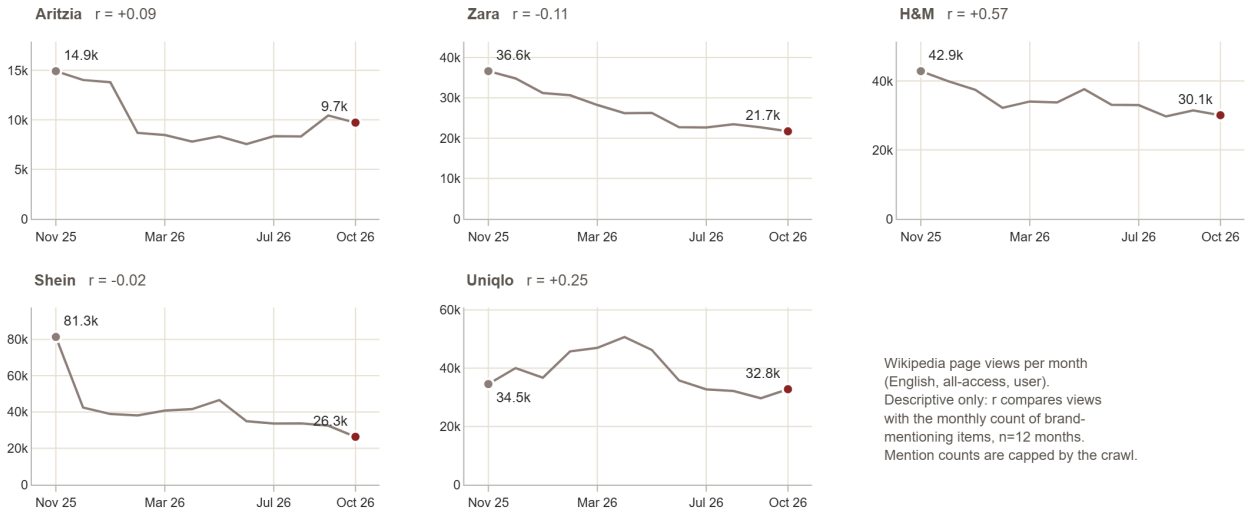
SUPPORTING VIEW

Public interest in each core brand over the 12 months

Descriptive only. The audited report draws no conclusion from this chart, so there is no so-what or recommendation here.

Public interest by brand over 12 months (descriptive)

Monthly English Wikipedia page views for the five core brands; each panel has its own scale. Red dot marks the latest month.



Wikipedia page views per month (English, all-access, user). Descriptive only: r compares views with the monthly count of brand-mentioning items, n=12 months. Mention counts are capped by the crawl.

Source: data/metrics.json, modules.trend. Wikipedia monthly page views (en, all-access, user); collection window 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31.

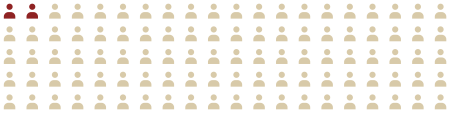
Chapter B **Who is talking**

This chapter answers: Who is talking, by age, gender and country?

MODULE 03 · PROFILING

03 Few authors report an age, and among those who do, the Gen Z and Millennial shares overlap, so the audience cannot be described reliably

Who states an age



33 of 1,453 brand-mentioning authors state an age: 2.27%, shown as 2 of 100 icons (rounded to the nearest whole icon).

The 33 who do



● 19 Gen Z ● 13 Millennial ● 1 older

19 Gen Z, 13 Millennial, 1 aged 46 or older (one icon per author). The Gen Z and Millennial intervals overlap.

Gender and country



● 11 female ● 2 male



● 10 US ● 11 Canada

Base too small for percentages: 13 authors reported gender, 21 reported country.

2.3%

of brand-mentioning authors state an age

33 of 1,453 authors; 95% CI 1.6% to 3.2%

THE QUESTION

Who is talking, by age, gender and country?

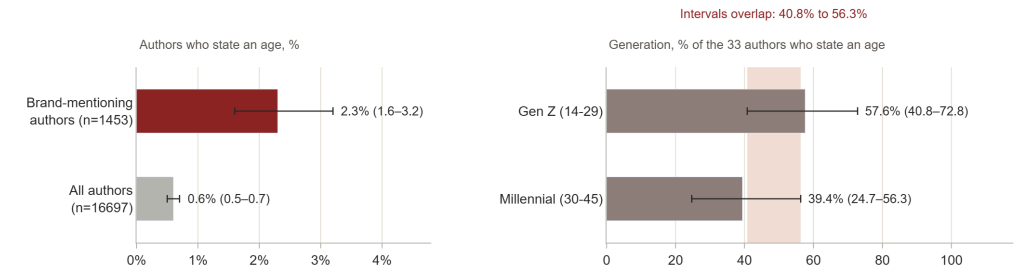
THE DECISION

Whether the listening data can stand in for Fieldnote's target shopper in the US and Canada.

WHAT WE FOUND

Age self-report coverage and the Gen Z vs Millennial split

Median stated age 25. 1 author (3.0%) is 46 or older and is not shown. Gender (13 authors) and country (21) have a base too small to chart.



Source: data/metrics.json, modules.profiling. Reddit (general subreddits) via Arctic Shift; collection window 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31.

SO WHAT

The generation split rests on a few dozen people, and the intervals for Gen Z and Millennial overlap. The data cannot separate the US from Canada.

WHAT FIELDNOTE SHOULD DO

Fieldnote should draw its US and Canada audience profile from the survey, quota-sampled on age, gender and country, not from these posts.

Chapter C

Brand image and positioning: what each brand stands for

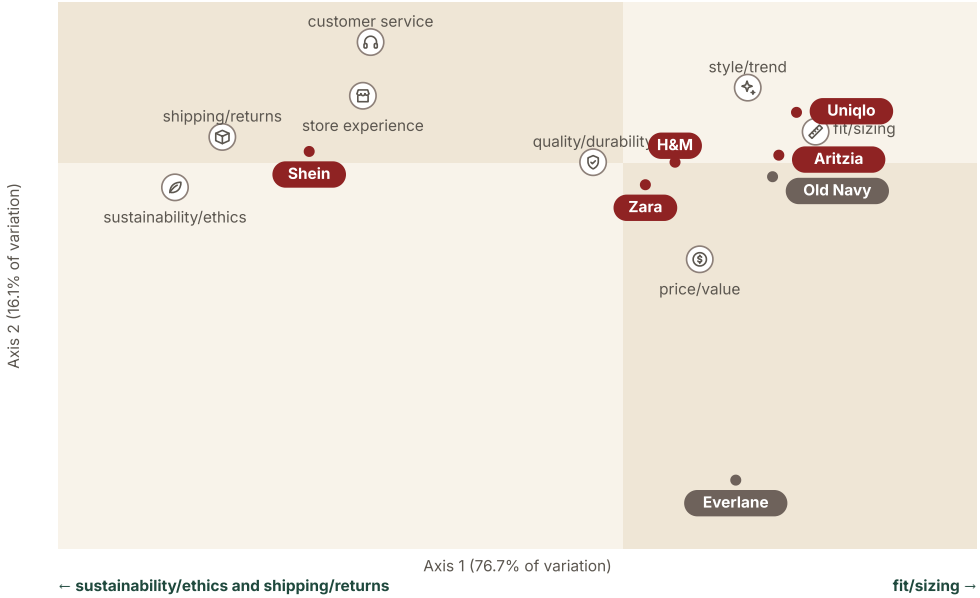
This chapter answers: Which attributes is each brand talked about for? How positive or negative is the talk about each brand?

MODULE 04 · POSITIONING

04 Shein is discussed more for sustainability and ethics, and Uniqlo more for style and trend, than the other brands

WHAT WE FOUND

Positioning quadrant: brands and attributes. Each chip is a brand, each icon an attribute; a brand sits near the attributes it is talked about for. Red chips are core brands, grey is not in the core set.



In plain words. *z* (adjusted standardized residual) is how far above or below the expected count a cell is; Bonferroni is a stricter bar for calling a cell unusual, because we test many cells at once; correspondence analysis is a map that puts brands and attributes close together when they are often talked about together.

45 VS 22

Shein talk about sustainability and ethics: sentences found vs about 22 expected

exact expected count: 21.6

THE QUESTION

Which attributes is each brand talked about for?

THE DECISION

Which attribute territory Fieldnote can claim that is not already tied to a competitor.

SO WHAT

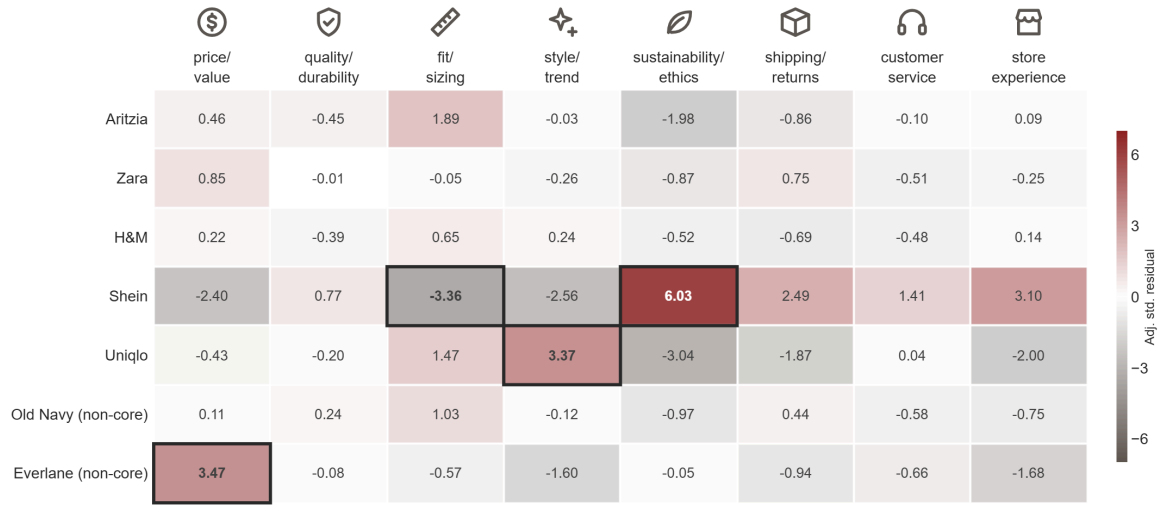
Price/value and quality/durability come up for every core brand, so they do not differentiate. Style/trend is already associated with Uniqlo, and Shein carries the ethics conversation. Fit/sizing is a lower share of Shein talk than expected, which leaves it open as a territory.

WHAT FIELDNOTE SHOULD DO

Fieldnote should test a trend-led, fit-reliable proposition against Zara and Uniqlo, and avoid competing on price talk, where the five brands already sit.

Brand x attribute adjusted standardised residuals

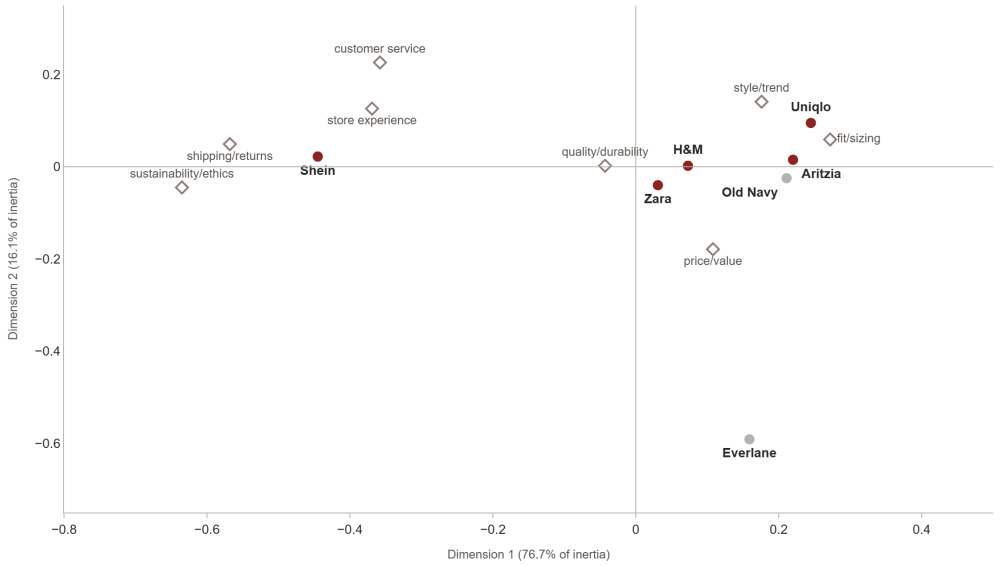
Red = more talk than expected, grey = less. Bold, outlined cells survive the Bonferroni correction (|z| > 3.32, 56 cells). Counts are sentences, not authors, so p-values are indicative.



Source: data/metrics.json, modules.positioning.adjusted_std_residuals. Reddit (general subreddits) via Arctic Shift; collection window 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31.

Perceptual map: brands and attributes (correspondence analysis)

Red dots are brands (grey: not in the core set); open diamonds are attributes. Brands near an attribute are talked about for it. Total inertia 0.0916; dimensions 1 and 2 hold 92.8%.



Source: data/metrics.json, modules.positioning.correspondence_analysis. Reddit (general subreddits) via Arctic Shift; collection window 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31.

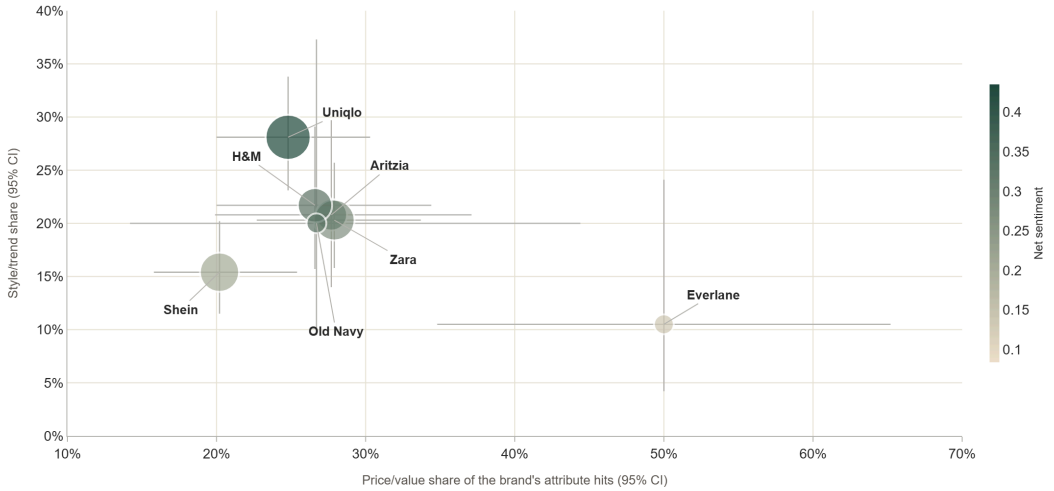
SUPPLEMENTARY, NOT AUDITED

ADDED AFTER THE AUDITED KEEPLOOP CYCLE; NOT PART OF REPORT.MD

WHAT WE FOUND

Zara, Aritzia and H&M sit within 1.3 points of each other on price/value share; Uniqlo leads on style/trend (28.1%) and Shein is lowest on both

Positioning map. Bubble area = mention sentences, colour = net sentiment, cross-hair bars = 95% CI. Most price-share intervals overlap; Everlane is furthest out on price (50.0%) and Shein is lowest among the core brands on price and on style/trend.



Source: data/metrics.json, supplementary.positioning_map. Reddit (general subreddits) via Arctic Shift; supplementary analysis, not audited; collection window 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31.

What the chart shows

Price/value share runs from 20.2% (Shein) to 50.0% (Everlane, not a core brand); style/trend share is highest for Uniqlo at 28.1%.

Read with care

The 95%% intervals are wide and most overlap on price share, so differences between the core brands on price are not clear. Shares are of attribute hits, not of consumers. Old Navy and Everlane are not in the core set.

MODULE 05 · PERCEPTION

05 Shein and Zara draw more negative sentences than Aritzia, Uniqlo or H&M, but the tool understates negativity

WHAT WE FOUND

Positive and negative share of single-brand sentences, by brand

Brands sorted by net sentiment = (positive - negative) / all sentences. Green bars are positive share, orange bars negative share. VADER agreed with hand labels on 64% of 50 sentences, so negativity is likely understated.



Source: data/metrics.json, modules.perception.by_brand. Reddit (general subreddits) via Arctic Shift; collection window 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31.

App Store review text could not be collected. Store-level US averages (all-time, not a sample): Aritzia 4.91, Zara 4.82, H&M 4.84, Shein 4.73, Uniqlo 4.78.

In plain words. VADER is an automatic positive/negative word scorer; kappa is agreement beyond chance.

23.6%

of Shein's sentences are negative

n=356 sentences; 95% CI 19.5% to 28.3%; VADER understates negativity

THE QUESTION

How positive or negative is the talk about each brand?

THE DECISION

Which competitor weaknesses Fieldnote can credibly exploit, and which brand strengths it can borrow.

SO WHAT

The gap in negative talk is the most defensible perception finding here, but the tool misses much criticism and the sentiment is toward sentences, not buyers.

WHAT FIELDNOTE SHOULD DO

Fieldnote should treat Zara's higher share of negative talk as a lead to investigate, not a proven weakness, and should measure brand attribute ratings in the survey.

SUPPLEMENTARY, NOT AUDITED

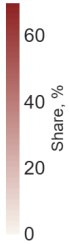
ADDED AFTER THE AUDITED KEEPLOOP CYCLE; NOT PART OF REPORT.MD

WHAT WE FOUND

In image talk the most common image is premium/aspirational for Zara and H&M (26.1%, 28.9%), cheap/disposable for Shein (31.4%), basic/everyday for Uniqlo (66.7%)

Brand image association grid. Share of each brand's image-coded sentences that carry the image (a sentence can carry several), with the 95% CI under it. Brands under 30 image-coded sentences are not shown: Aritzia (27 sentences) and the wider brands.

	premium/ aspirational	cheap/ disposable	trendy/ fashion-forward	dated/ frumpy	comfortable	uncomfortable	ethical/ responsible	unethical/ exploitative	reliable/ consistent	inconsistent/ hit-or-miss	basic/ everyday	Canadian/ local	fun/ young
Zara (n=69)	26.1% 17 to 38	14.5% 8 to 25	23.2% 15 to 34	4.3% 2 to 12	5.8% 2 to 14	2.9% 1 to 10	2.9% 1 to 10	0.0% 0 to 5	4.3% 2 to 12	7.2% 3 to 16	13.0% 7 to 23	5.8% 2 to 14	5.8% 2 to 14
H&M (n=45)	28.9% 18 to 43	13.3% 6 to 26	11.1% 5 to 24	2.2% 0 to 12	11.1% 5 to 24	2.2% 0 to 12	2.2% 0 to 12	2.2% 0 to 12	6.7% 2 to 18	4.4% 1 to 15	13.3% 6 to 26	0.0% 0 to 8	13.3% 6 to 26
Shein (n=70)	11.4% 6 to 21	31.4% 22 to 43	14.3% 8 to 24	4.3% 2 to 12	0.0% 0 to 5	1.4% 0 to 8	12.9% 7 to 23	8.6% 4 to 18	2.9% 1 to 10	2.9% 1 to 10	4.3% 2 to 12	1.4% 0 to 8	10.0% 5 to 19
Uniqlo (n=75)	6.7% 3 to 15	9.3% 5 to 18	0.0% 0 to 5	2.7% 1 to 9	13.3% 7 to 23	1.3% 0 to 7	0.0% 0 to 5	0.0% 0 to 5	13.3% 7 to 23	0.0% 0 to 5	**66.7% 55 to 76**	2.7% 1 to 9	1.3% 0 to 7
Set average	17.0%	17.4%	12.0%	3.5%	7.3%	1.9%	4.6%	2.7%	6.9%	3.5%	26.3%	2.7%	6.9%



Source: data/metrics.json, supplementary.brand_image.association_grid. Reddit (general subreddits) via Arctic Shift; supplementary analysis, not audited; collection window 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31.

What the chart shows

The image carried by the largest share of each brand's image-coded sentences: Zara: premium/aspirational 26.1%; H&M: premium/aspirational 28.9%; Shein: cheap/disposable 31.4%; Uniqlo: basic/everyday 66.7%. The set average for that image differs by brand.

Read with care

Shares of talk, not of consumers. Aritzia has too few image-coded sentences (27) and the wider brands are base too small. A keyword can match without praise.

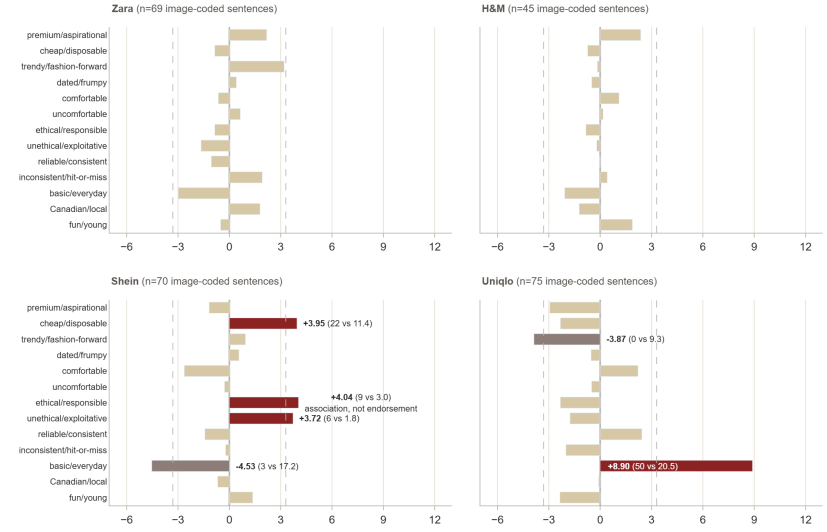
SUPPLEMENTARY, NOT AUDITED

ADDED AFTER THE AUDITED KEEPLOOP CYCLE; NOT PART OF REPORT.MD

WHAT WE FOUND

Shein over-indexes on cheap/disposable, ethical/responsible, unethical/exploitative and under on basic/everyday; Uniqlo over-indexes on basic/everyday and under on trendy/fashion-forward

Image strengths and weaknesses against the set average. Adjusted standardised residual of each brand x image cell; dashed lines mark the Bonferroni threshold (|z| > 3.3). Coloured bars are flagged. Flagged means more or less talk than average, not praise: keyword association is not endorsement.



Source: data/metrics.json, supplementary.brand_image.adjusted_std_residuals. Reddit (general subreddits) via Arctic Shift; supplementary analysis, not audited; collection window 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31.

What the chart shows

6 cells pass the Bonferroni threshold (|z| > 3.3): Shein basic/everyday under (-4.53); Shein cheap/disposable over (+3.95); Shein ethical/responsible over (+4.04); Shein unethical/exploitative over (+3.72); Uniqlo basic/everyday over (+8.90); Uniqlo trendy/fashion-forward under (-3.87).

Read with care

Shein's ethical/responsible flag rests on 9 sentences and is mostly critical ethics talk: association, not endorsement. It is not read as a strength. Cell sentiment is base too small for every flagged cell except Uniqlo basic/everyday. In plain words: z (adjusted standardized residual) is how far above or below the expected count a cell is; Bonferroni is a stricter bar for calling a cell unusual, because we test many cells at once.

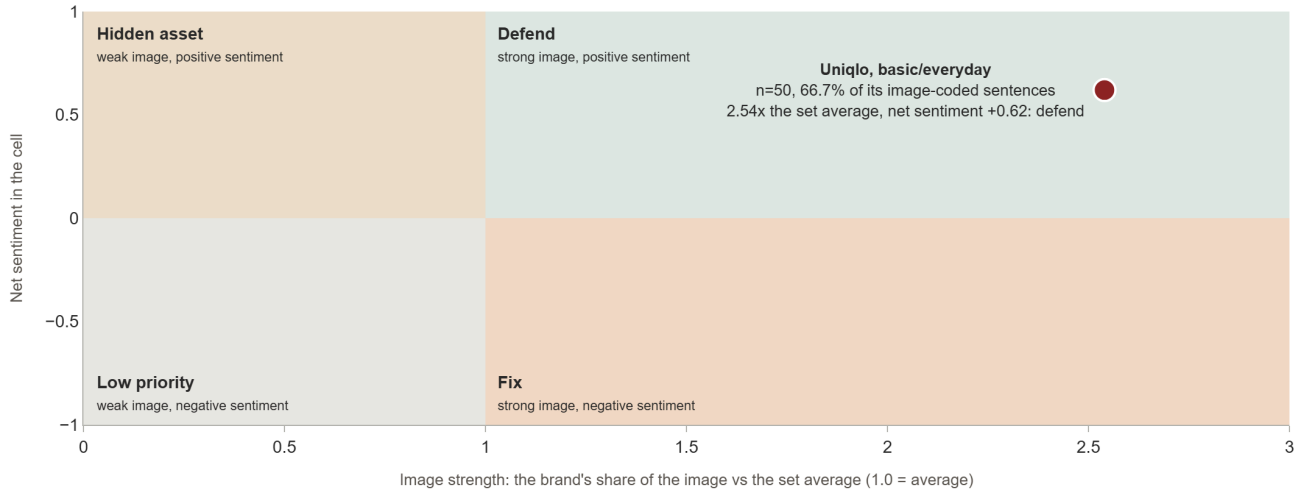
SUPPLEMENTARY, NOT AUDITED

ADDED AFTER THE AUDITED KEEPLOOP CYCLE; NOT PART OF REPORT.MD

WHAT WE FOUND

Only 1 cell has enough sentences to place: Uniqlo's basic/everyday image, at 2.5 times the set average with net sentiment +0.62

Image priority quadrant. Only cells with at least 30 sentences are placed: 1 cell is placed and 44 brand x image cells are not. Aritzia has too few image-coded sentences (27) to be placed.



Source: data/metrics.json, supplementary.brand_image.priority_quadrant. Reddit (general subreddits) via Arctic Shift; supplementary analysis, not audited; collection window 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31.

What the chart shows

1 cell is placed: Uniqlo, basic/everyday (n=50, 2.54 times the set average, net sentiment +0.62), which the rule puts in the "defend" quadrant. 44 other brand x image cells have fewer than 30 sentences and are not placed.

Read with care

Aritzia has too few image-coded sentences (27) to be placed. The quadrant sorts one cell; it does not rank the brands.

IN THEIR WORDS

Quotes, one per brand from the price/value cell

"If you want to splurge (200$ range per piece), try Aritzia!"

Aritzia, price/value · cell of 28 sentences

"I still wear Zara and Banana Republic stuff from 20 years ago because I don't treat any of my clothes like they're cheap."

Zara, price/value · cell of 70 sentences

"I have one acrylic sweater that I sort of like, but it was a $15 H&M buy."

H&M, price/value · cell of 38 sentences

"I do think SHEIN overall has much lower quality far more consistently, but I agree that mainstream retail quality has declined aggressively while prices climb."

Shein, price/value · cell of 54 sentences

"Uniqlo mini tee is my favorite at an affordable price point"

Uniqlo, price/value · cell of 67 sentences

Quote rule. each cell's quotes are the sentences closest to the cell's median sentiment, one per author; from the price/value cell I took one per brand, picking the one that reads as a complete sentence without text-encoding damage. This is an editorial choice among rule-selected quotes.

Chapter D

Segments and target

This chapter answers: Which groups of people have similar brand and attribute talk, and which should Fieldnote target first?

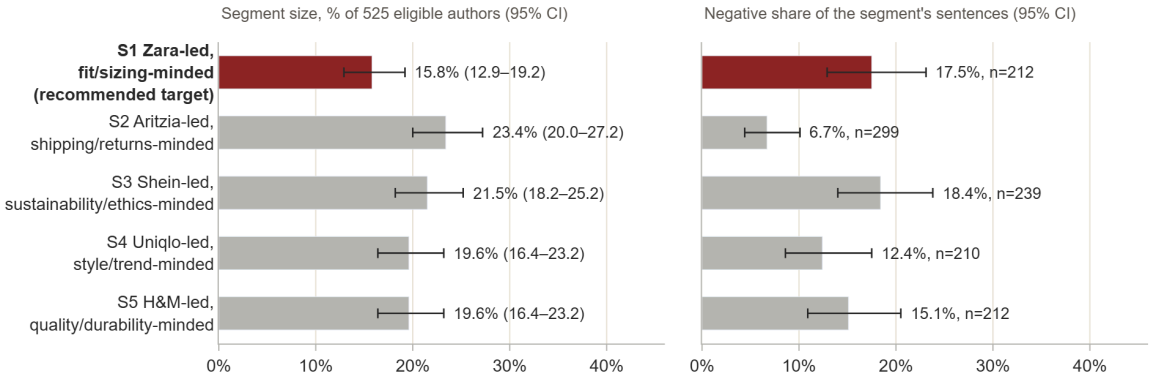
MODULE 06 · SEGMENTATION

06 Five talk groups emerge, but they overlap, and the Zara-led group is the suggested first target

WHAT WE FOUND

Talk segments: size and negative share

Authors with at least two brand-mention sentences, grouped into k=5 segments (silhouette 0.189, weak). Size intervals overlap, so size alone does not decide the target.



Source: data/metrics.json, modules.segmentation. Reddit (general subreddits) via Arctic Shift; collection window 2025-11-01 to 2026-10-31.

In plain words. silhouette is how distinct the groups are, from 0 (not at all) to 1 (clearly separate).

15.8%

of eligible authors are in Segment 1, the Zara-led group

83 of 525 authors; 95% CI 12.9% to 19.2%

THE QUESTION

Which groups of people have similar brand and attribute talk, and which should Fieldnote target first?

THE DECISION

Which segment Fieldnote builds its first-year US and Canada plan around.

SO WHAT

Segment 1 is the smallest of the five but is built around the brand closest to Fieldnote's mid-priced, trend-led positioning, and its talk carries a higher share of negative sentences than the Aritzia-led or Uniqlo-led groups. Segment 2 is larger but already positive about its brand, leaving less to win. These intervals for segment size overlap, so size alone does not decide the choice.

WHAT FIELDNOTE SHOULD DO

Fieldnote should target the Zara-led segment first as a working hypothesis, with fit and sizing as the lead proposition, and confirm the segment's size, age and country mix in a survey before committing the plan.

S1 Zara-led, fit/sizing-minded

Recommended target



Size	**15.8%** of eligible authors (n=525, 95% CI 12.9% to 19.2%)
Lead brand	**Zara** 64.7% of its brand mentions
Talks most about	**price/value** 16.4% of its sentences
Net sentiment	**+0.292**
Negative share	**17.5%** (n=212, 95% CI 12.9% to 23.1%)

"Personally I like their confusion as I stumble upon more and more zara clothes at ridicilous prices in TJ Maxx that I can experiment with."

Zara, price/value (rule-selected quote)

S2 Aritzia-led, shipping/returns-minded



Size	**23.4%** of eligible authors (n=525, 95% CI 20.0% to 27.2%)
Lead brand	**Aritzia** 27.9% of its brand mentions
Talks most about	**price/value** 8.5% of its sentences
Net sentiment	**+0.428**
Negative share	**6.7%** (n=299, 95% CI 4.4% to 10.1%)

"If you want to splurge (200$ range per piece), try Aritzia!"

Aritzia, price/value (rule-selected quote)

S3 Shein-led, sustainability/ethics-minded



Size	**21.5%** of eligible authors (n=525, 95% CI 18.2% to 25.2%)
Lead brand	**Shein** 56.7% of its brand mentions
Talks most about	**price/value** 12.9% of its sentences
Net sentiment	**+0.197**
Negative share	**18.4%** (n=239, 95% CI 14.0% to 23.8%)

"There are even lead concerns with clothes from shein so I figured it's not worth the risk."

Shein, price/value (rule-selected quote)

S4 Uniqlo-led, style/trend-minded



Size	**19.6%** of eligible authors (n=525, 95% CI 16.4% to 23.2%)
Lead brand	**Uniqlo** 64.2% of its brand mentions
Talks most about	**style/trend** 13.3% of its sentences
Net sentiment	**+0.405**
Negative share	**12.4%** (n=210, 95% CI 8.6% to 17.5%)

"there's lots of layering options too, so you can keep it as exposured as conservative as you want long live UNIQLO for queer basics lol"

Uniqlo, style/trend (rule-selected quote)

S5 H&M-led, quality/durability-minded



Size	**19.6%** of eligible authors (n=525, 95% CI 16.4% to 23.2%)
Lead brand	**H&M** 47.8% of its brand mentions
Talks most about	**price/value** 11.7% of its sentences
Net sentiment	**+0.259**
Negative share	**15.1%** (n=212, 95% CI 10.9% to 20.5%)

"I have one acrylic sweater that I sort of like, but it was a $15 H&M buy."

H&M, price/value (rule-selected quote)

Badges are segment numbers, not people. The ring is the segment's share of the 525 eligible authors. No age, gender or country profile is shown for any segment: the base per segment is too small (report.md).

WHAT IT MEANS FOR FIELDNOTE

What the audited report recommends, grouped by decision

These are the report's own recommendations, verbatim and unchanged; nothing is added here.

Where to play (the segment)

Module 06, Segmentation

Fieldnote should target the Zara-led segment first as a working hypothesis, with fit and sizing as the lead proposition, and confirm the segment's size, age and country mix in a survey before committing the plan.

How to win (positioning)

Module 04, Positioning

Fieldnote should test a trend-led, fit-reliable proposition against Zara and Uniqlo, and avoid competing on price talk, where the five brands already sit.

Module 05, Perception

Fieldnote should treat Zara's higher share of negative talk as a lead to investigate, not a proven weakness, and should measure brand attribute ratings in the survey.

What to validate (in the survey)

Module 01, Top-of-mind

Fieldnote should not read this module as a ranking of the womenswear market, and should add an aided and unaided awareness question to the validating survey before setting any awareness target.

Module 02, Penetration

Fieldnote should not claim a penetration gap against any competitor from this data and should measure claimed ownership in the survey.

Module 03, Profiling

Fieldnote should draw its US and Canada audience profile from the survey, quota-sampled on age, gender and country, not from these posts.

⚠ Caveats on the evidence

- Module 05's title says Shein and Zara draw more negative sentences than Aritzia, Uniqlo or H&M, but Zara's interval (14.8% to 22.5%) overlaps H&M's (7.5% to 15.1%). Only the gap to Aritzia and Uniqlo is clear of overlap.
- Module 06 says Segment 1 carries a higher negative share than the Uniqlo-led group, but their intervals overlap (12.9% to 23.1% vs 8.6% to 17.5%). Only the Aritzia-led group is clearly lower.
- The Summary says to position on trend and fit, while module 04 ties style/trend to Uniqlo (z=+3.37, survives Bonferroni). The audit of the report already flagged this as the next card (run/cycle-2/audit.txt).
- The Summary says Zara is discussed mostly for price and quality, but module 04 finds that price/value and quality/durability come up for every core brand, so they do not differentiate Zara from the others.
- The Summary's phrase "the most open dissatisfaction" is an unsupported superlative: Zara's negative share (14.8% to 22.5%) overlaps H&M's, and Shein's (23.6%) is higher than Zara's (18.4%).

In plain words. *z* (adjusted standardized residual) is how far above or below the expected count a cell is; Bonferroni is a stricter bar for calling a cell unusual, because we test many cells at once.

NEXT STEPS

Validate with a survey before committing the plan

The next study

A fielded survey on a representative sample of Gen Z and Millennial shoppers in the US and Canada, to validate awareness, ownership, profile, attribute ratings and the size of the Zara-led segment. Pricing tests, ad creative and product concepts remain out of scope.

A draft questionnaire exists

A draft questionnaire for this brief is in ../run/cycle-1/; it runs longer than the 10-minute budget and needs shortening before fieldwork.

APPENDIX

Methodology and definitions

Evidence is social listening, not a survey: public Reddit posts and comments from November 2025 to October 2026 through the Arctic Shift archive, App Store store-level ratings, and Wikipedia page views. The analysis covers 29507 Reddit items from 16697 authors; 1865 items and 1453 authors mention a brand, giving 2779 brand-mention sentences, of which 2100 name a single brand and 679 name several and are excluded from sentiment and attributes. Cross-brand modules use general subreddits only, so fan communities do not favour their own brand. Brands were found by name search with one dictionary applied to all five core brands.

Limits to keep in mind:

- Social media is not a representative sample of North American Gen Z and Millennial shoppers; Reddit is self-selected, and who posts there is not measured in this data.
- The collection was time-boxed and partial. The general-subreddit sample is mainly femalefashionadvice keyword search plus recommendation-thread replies, and 10 time windows were given up after retries.
- 48 of the 60 recommendation threads are menswear, so top-of-mind results lean to menswear-friendly brands.
- Top-of-mind, penetration and positioning are proxies, not survey measures.
- Age, gender and country are self-reported by few authors, so generation and country splits are mostly base too small, and Canada cannot be separated from the US.
- VADER agreement with hand labels is moderate (64%, n=50, 95% CI 50.1% to 75.9%) and it understates negativity.
- Segments are weak (low silhouette) and describe talk patterns, not shopper types.
- App Store review text failed to collect; only store-level ratings exist, and no review sentiment is reported.
- No subreddit with data exists for Zara or H&M, so their within-brand context is missing.

Definitions, including the proxies

Top-of-mind (unaided awareness proxy) Base: top-level replies (one per author per thread) in selected recommendation threads that name at least one brand. First mention = the brand with the earliest position in the reply; total mention = share of those replies naming the brand (multiple response). Caveat: recommenders answer for the asker, thread selection is by reply count, and 48 of the 60 threads are menswear (sample_composition_warning), so the result leans to menswear-friendly brands. Not an awareness measure for Gen Z or Millennial women.

Penetration proxy Distinct authors with at least one ownership or purchase phrase in a sentence naming the brand ("I bought", "ordered from", "my ... from", "haul", ...) divided by distinct authors with any brand mention. A proxy, not penetration: the base is only authors who discussed brands, and phrase matching misses and over-catches. Values are small by construction.

Profiling Self-reported age ("(24F)", "I'm 24", "24 y/o", "born in 1998"; accepted range 14-65), gender ("(24F)", "as a guy", "I'm a woman"), country (first-person cues such as "I live in Toronto", "here in Canada", "as an American"). First report by an author wins. Gen Z = 14-29, Millennial = 30-45, Older = 46+ (in 2026). Coverage is reported per group; it is very low (about 2% of brand-mentioning authors give an age), so generation results rest on tiny bases and are mostly "base too small".

Positioning Brand x attribute matrix of single-brand sentences that hit an attribute keyword (a sentence can hit several). Attribute dictionaries are in dictionaries.attributes (price/value, quality/durability, fit/sizing, style/trend, sustainability/ethics, shipping/returns, customer service, store experience). Brands enter the matrix with at least 30 attribute hits. Correspondence analysis: $P = N/n$, $S = (P - r\,c^T)/\mathrm{sqrt}(r\,c^T)$, SVD of S, axis inertia = D^2, total inertia = chi^2/n. Chi-square of independence with df = (R-1)(C-1); adjusted standardised residual = (O-E)/sqrt(E(1 - row/n)(1 - col/n)), flagged at $|z| > 1.96$ and separately at a Bonferroni threshold. Hits are not independent (one author can contribute several), so p-values are indicative.

Perception VADER (Hutto and Gilbert, 2014, ICWSM) compound score per single-brand sentence; positive >= 0.05, negative <= -0.05, else neutral. Net sentiment = (pos - neg) / (pos + neg + neu), with Wilson intervals on the positive and negative shares, per brand and per brand x attribute.

Segmentation Authors with at least 2 brand-mention sentences. Vector = share of the author's mention sentences per brand (brands with at least 50 mentions, plus "other") and share touching each attribute. k-means (scikit-learn, 10 starts, seed 0), k = 2..6 by silhouette. Segment names are mechanical: highest brand lift (at least 10% share) plus highest attribute lift. The silhouette is low (see metrics.json), so these are talk patterns, not validated shopper types.

Trend Wikipedia monthly views per brand next to monthly counts of brand-mentioning items. Mention counts are bounded by collection caps and by which searches ran; use share of voice, not growth. Pearson r over 12 months is descriptive only.

APPENDIX

How we calculated this

Each formula, with this run's values plugged in and the source of the formula.

Wilson 95% interval

$$\hat{p} = \frac{k}{n}, \qquad \mathrm{CI}_{95} = \frac{\hat{p} + \frac{z^2}{2n} \pm z\sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})}{n} + \frac{z^2}{4n^2}}}{1 + \frac{z^2}{n}}, \; z = 1.96$$

Run value, Uniqlo first mention: k=92, n=217, so p=0.424 and the interval is 36.0% to 49.0% (matches metrics.json)

`metrics.json: centre=(p+z^2/2n)/(1+z^2/n); half=z*sqrt(p(1-p)/n+z^2/4n^2)/(1+z^2/n); z=1.96`

Source: Wilson (1927), J. American Statistical Association 22(158):209-212. Used for every interval in this report; shown only where the base is at least 30.

Net sentiment

$$\text{net} = \frac{n_{pos} - n_{neg}}{n_{pos} + n_{neg} + n_{neu}}$$

$$\text{Zara}: \; \frac{176 - 72}{176 + 72 + 144} = 0.265$$

`metrics.json: (pos - neg) / (pos + neg + neu), VADER compound: pos >= 0.05, neg <= -0.05, else neu`

Source: Hutto and Gilbert (2014), VADER, Proc. ICWSM: compound score; positive at 0.05 or more, negative at -0.05 or less. The share-difference definition is the one recorded in metrics.json.

First-mention and total-mention share

$$\text{first}_b = \frac{k_b^{first}}{n}, \qquad \text{total}_b = \frac{k_b^{total}}{n}$$

$$\text{Uniqlo}: \; \frac{92}{217} = 42.4\%, \qquad \frac{95}{217} = 43.8\%$$

n counts top-level replies that name any brand; total-mention shares can sum to more than 100%.

`metrics.json: k = top-level replies whose first-named brand (earliest text position) is b; base = replies naming any brand; one reply per author per thread`

Source: Standard share of a multiple-response base; definitions in data/README.md (Methods, item 1).

Penetration proxy

$$\text{pen}_b = \frac{\#\text{ authors with an ownership phrase about } b}{\#\text{ authors with any brand mention}}$$

$$\text{Zara}: \; \frac{33}{1453} = 2.3\%$$

A proxy by construction: phrase matching and a base of brand-talkers only.

`metrics.json: k = distinct authors with >= 1 ownership/purchase phrase in a sentence naming b; base = distinct authors with >= 1 brand mention`

Source: Proportion with a Wilson interval; the ownership-phrase list is in metrics.json (dictionaries.ownership_phrases).

Chi-square, adjusted residual, Bonferroni

$$\chi^2 = \sum \frac{(O-E)^2}{E}, \quad E = \frac{\text{row} \cdot \text{col}}{n}, \quad \text{df} = (R-1)(C-1)$$

$$\chi^2 = 100.75, \; \text{df} = (7-1)(8-1) = 42, \; n = 1100$$

$$z = \frac{O - E}{\sqrt{E\left(1 - \frac{\text{row}}{n}\right)\left(1 - \frac{\text{col}}{n}\right)}}$$

$$\text{Shein, sustainability/ethics}: \; O = 45, \; E = 21.6, \; z = 6.03$$

$$|z| > \Phi^{-1}\left(1 - \tfrac{0.05/m}{2}\right) = 3.32, \; m = 56 \text{ cells}$$

Hits are not independent (one author can add several), so p-values are indicative.

`metrics.json: (O-E)/sqrt(E*(1-row/n)*(1-col/n)); flagged |z|>1.96 and, stricter, |z|> Bonferroni z for alpha=.05/cells`

Source: Haberman (1973), Biometrics 29(1):205-220 (adjusted residuals); Agresti (2002), Categorical Data Analysis; Dunn (1961), J. American Statistical Association 56(293):52-64 (Bonferroni).

Correspondence analysis

$$P = N/n, \quad S = D_r^{-1/2}(P - rc^\top)D_c^{-1/2} = UDV^\top$$

$$\lambda_k = d_k^2, \quad \sum_k \lambda_k = \frac{\chi^2}{n}$$

$$\frac{\chi^2}{n} = \frac{100.75}{1100} = 0.0916, \quad \lambda_1 = 0.0702 \; (76.7\%), \; \lambda_2 = 0.0148 \; (16.1\%)$$

Row coordinates are U D / sqrt(r), column coordinates V D / sqrt(c); the axis percentages label the map.

`metrics.json: P=N/n; r,c = margins; S=(P-rc^T)/sqrt(rc^T); S=U*D*V^T; row coords=U*D/sqrt(r); col coords=V*D/sqrt(c); axis inertia=D^2; total inertia=chi2/n`

Source: Benzecri (1973), L'analyse des donnees; Greenacre (2017), Correspondence Analysis in Practice, 3rd ed., CRC Press.

k-means and silhouette

$$\min \sum_{j=1}^{k} \sum_{x \in C_j} \|x - \mu_j\|^2$$

$$s(i) = \frac{b(i) - a(i)}{\max\{a(i), b(i)\}}, \quad \bar{s} = \frac{1}{N}\sum_i s(i)$$

a(i): mean distance to the author's own group; b(i): mean distance to the nearest other group. Mean silhouette by number of groups (N=525 authors):



k=5 is the highest (0.189); a value this low means weak separation.

`metrics.json: repertoire vector = share of author's brand-mention sentences per brand (+ 'other') and share touching each attribute; KMeans n_init=10 seed 0; k in 2..6 by silhouette`

Source: Lloyd (1982), IEEE Trans. Information Theory 28(2):129-137; Rousseeuw (1987), J. Computational and Applied Mathematics 20:53-65; scikit-learn (Pedregosa et al., 2011, JMLR 12:2825-2830), 10 starts, seed 0.

Cohen's kappa (VADER check)

$$\kappa = \frac{p_o - p_e}{1 - p_e}, \qquad p_e = \sum_i \frac{r_i c_i}{N^2}$$

$$p_o = \tfrac{32}{50} = 0.64, \;\; p_e = 0.347, \;\; \kappa = \frac{0.64 - 0.347}{1 - 0.347} = 0.45$$

Agreement 64% (Wilson 95% CI 50.1% to 75.9%); kappa 0.45 reads as moderate. One labeller, so no inter-rater reliability.

Source: Cohen (1960), Educational and Psychological Measurement 20(1):37-46; Landis and Koch (1977), Biometrics 33(1):159-174 (bands). Not in metrics.json formulas; computed from its confusion matrix.

Pearson r (trend)

$$r = \frac{\sum_t (x_t - \bar{x})(y_t - \bar{y})}{\sqrt{\sum_t (x_t - \bar{x})^2 \sum_t (y_t - \bar{y})^2}}$$

x: Wikipedia views per month, y: brand-mentioning items per month, t = 12 months. Run values: Aritzia +0.09; Zara -0.11; H&M +0.57; Shein -0.02; Uniqlo +0.25. Descriptive only.

Source: Pearson (1895), Proc. Royal Society of London 58:240-242. The formula is not listed in metrics.json; the r values are, and build.py recomputes them.

APPENDIX

Data tables

The numbers behind each chart, as plotted.

First-mention share of brand-naming replies, by brand

Brand	First named	Named at all	Replies (k of n)
Uniqlo	42.4% (36.0–49.0)	43.8% (37.3–50.4)	92 of 217
Lululemon	10.1% (6.8–14.9)	10.6% (7.2–15.4)	22 of 217
Abercrombie	8.8% (5.7–13.3)	11.5% (7.9–16.5)	19 of 217
Old Navy	7.8% (4.9–12.2)	11.5% (7.9–16.5)	17 of 217
Madewell	4.6% (2.5–8.3)	5.1% (2.9–8.8)	10 of 217
American Eagle	4.1% (2.2–7.7)	4.1% (2.2–7.7)	9 of 217
Everlane	3.7% (1.9–7.1)	5.5% (3.2–9.4)	8 of 217
Gap	3.7% (1.9–7.1)	5.5% (3.2–9.4)	8 of 217
Zara	3.2% (1.6–6.5)	3.7% (1.9–7.1)	7 of 217
COS	2.8% (1.3–5.9)	3.2% (1.6–6.5)	6 of 217
H&M	1.8% (0.7–4.6)	2.3% (1.0–5.3)	4 of 217
Aritzia	0.9% (0.3–3.3)	1.8% (0.7–4.6)	2 of 217
Free People	0.9% (0.3–3.3)	0.9% (0.3–3.3)	2 of 217
Reformation	0.9% (0.3–3.3)	1.4% (0.5–4.0)	2 of 217
Shein	0.9% (0.3–3.3)	1.4% (0.5–4.0)	2 of 217
Simons	0.9% (0.3–3.3)	0.9% (0.3–3.3)	2 of 217
Urban Outfitters	0.9% (0.3–3.3)	0.9% (0.3–3.3)	2 of 217
Hollister	0.5% (0.1–2.6)	0.5% (0.1–2.6)	1 of 217
Mango	0.5% (0.1–2.6)	0.9% (0.3–3.3)	1 of 217
Temu	0.5% (0.1–2.6)	0.5% (0.1–2.6)	1 of 217

Penetration proxy: authors with an ownership or purchase phrase

Brand	Share (95% CI)	Authors (k of n)
H&M	2.3% (1.7–3.3)	34 of 1453
Uniqlo	2.3% (1.6–3.2)	33 of 1453
Zara	2.3% (1.6–3.2)	33 of 1453
Shein	2.0% (1.4–2.9)	29 of 1453
Aritzia	1.7% (1.2–2.5)	25 of 1453

Age self-report coverage and the Gen Z vs Millennial split

Measure	Share (95% CI)	k of n
Age stated, brand-mentioning authors	2.3% (1.6–3.2)	33 of 1453
Age stated, all authors	0.6% (0.5–0.7)	98 of 16697
Gen Z (14-29)	57.6% (40.8–72.8)	19 of 33
Millennial (30-45)	39.4% (24.7–56.3)	13 of 33

Perceptual map: brands and attributes (correspondence analysis)

Point	Type	Dim 1	Dim 2
Aritzia	brand	0.220	0.015
Zara	brand	0.031	-0.040
H&M	brand	0.073	0.002
Shein	brand	-0.445	0.022
Uniqlo	brand	0.245	0.095
Old Navy	brand	0.211	-0.025
Everlane	brand	0.159	-0.591
price/value	attribute	0.108	-0.179
quality/durability	attribute	-0.043	0.002
fit/sizing	attribute	0.272	0.059
style/trend	attribute	0.176	0.141
sustainability/ethics	attribute	-0.635	-0.045
shipping/returns	attribute	-0.568	0.049
customer service	attribute	-0.358	0.226
store experience	attribute	-0.369	0.126

Brand x attribute adjusted standardised residuals

Brand	price/value	quality/durability	fit/sizing	style/trend	sustainability/ethics	shipping/returns	customer service	store experience
Aritzia	0.46	-0.45	1.89	-0.03	-1.98	-0.86	-0.10	0.09
Zara	0.85	-0.01	-0.05	-0.26	-0.87	0.75	-0.51	-0.25
H&M	0.22	-0.39	0.65	0.24	-0.52	-0.69	-0.48	0.14
Shein	-2.40	0.77	-3.36 *	-2.56	6.03 *	2.49	1.41	3.10
Uniqlo	-0.43	-0.20	1.47	3.37 *	-3.04	-1.87	0.04	-2.00
Old Navy	0.11	0.24	1.03	-0.12	-0.97	0.44	-0.58	-0.75
Everlane	3.47 *	-0.08	-0.57	-1.60	-0.05	-0.94	-0.66	-1.68

Positive and negative share of single-brand sentences, by brand

Brand	Sentences	Positive (95% CI)	Negative (95% CI)	Net sentiment
Uniqlo	504	51.0% (46.6–55.3)	7.5% (5.5–10.2)	+0.435
Aritzia	221	48.0% (41.5–54.5)	6.8% (4.2–10.9)	+0.412
H&M	252	43.7% (37.7–49.8)	10.7% (7.5–15.1)	+0.329
Zara	392	44.9% (40.0–49.8)	18.4% (14.8–22.5)	+0.265
Shein	356	43.8% (38.8–49.0)	23.6% (19.5–28.3)	+0.202

Talk segments: size and negative share

Segment	Authors	Size (95% CI)	Negative (95% CI)	Net sentiment
S1 Zara-led, fit/sizing-minded	83	15.8% (12.9–19.2)	17.5% (12.9–23.1)	+0.292
S2 Aritzia-led, shipping/returns-minded	123	23.4% (20.0–27.2)	6.7% (4.4–10.1)	+0.428
S3 Shein-led, sustainability/ethics-minded	113	21.5% (18.2–25.2)	18.4% (14.0–23.8)	+0.197
S4 Uniqlo-led, style/trend-minded	103	19.6% (16.4–23.2)	12.4% (8.6–17.5)	+0.405
S5 H&M-led, quality/durability-minded	103	19.6% (16.4–23.2)	15.1% (10.9–20.5)	+0.259

Public interest by brand over 12 months (descriptive)

Brand	Nov 25	Dec 25	Jan 26	Feb 26	Mar 26	Apr 26	May 26	Jun 26	Jul 26	Aug 26	Sep 26	Oct 26	r
Aritzia	14,923	14,031	13,800	8,685	8,470	7,805	8,339	7,550	8,351	8,327	10,442	9,718	+0.09
Zara	36,627	34,825	31,206	30,652	28,242	26,198	26,279	22,734	22,646	23,445	22,678	21,694	-0.11
H&M	42,854	39,943	37,435	32,209	34,047	33,777	37,630	33,107	32,995	29,717	31,447	30,069	+0.57
Shein	81,343	42,473	38,915	38,166	40,804	41,606	46,605	34,959	33,641	33,765	32,525	26,349	-0.02
Uniqlo	34,549	40,044	36,720	45,769	46,982	50,715	46,277	35,801	32,726	32,147	29,679	32,775	+0.25

Between 7% and 14% of the authors who mention each core brand also say they bought it; Advocate is too thin to measure

Brand	Aware (authors)	Considering, % of Aware	Bought, % of Aware	Bought / Considering	Advocate (k of Bought)
Aritzia	209	12.4% (8.6–17.6)	12.0% (8.2–17.1)	base too small	0 of 25
Zara	331	10.6% (7.7–14.4)	10.0% (7.2–13.7)	94.3% (81.4–98.4)	0 of 33
H&M	251	14.7% (10.9–19.7)	13.5% (9.9–18.3)	91.9% (78.7–97.2)	0 of 34
Shein	327	10.4% (7.5–14.2)	8.9% (6.2–12.4)	85.3% (69.9–93.6)	0 of 29
Uniqlo	443	8.1% (5.9–11.0)	7.4% (5.4–10.3)	91.7% (78.2–97.1)	1 of 33

In image talk the most common image is premium/aspirational for Zara and H&M (26.1%, 28.9%), cheap/disposable for Shein (31.4%), basic/everyday for Uniqlo (66.7%)

Brand	premium/aspirational	cheap/disposable	trendy/fashion-forward	dated/frumpy	comfortable	uncomfortable	eth
Zara	26.1% (17.2–37.5) (18 of 69)	14.5% (8.1–24.7) (10 of 69)	23.2% (14.8–34.4) (16 of 69)	4.3% (1.5–12.0) (3 of 69)	5.8% (2.3–14.0) (4 of 69)	2.9% (0.8–10.0) (2 of 69)	2.9
H&M	28.9% (17.7–43.4) (13 of 45)	13.3% (6.3–26.2) (6 of 45)	11.1% (4.8–23.5) (5 of 45)	2.2% (0.4–11.6) (1 of 45)	11.1% (4.8–23.5) (5 of 45)	2.2% (0.4–11.6) (1 of 45)	2.2
Shein	11.4% (5.9–21.0) (8 of 70)	31.4% (21.8–43.0) (22 of 70)	14.3% (7.9–24.3) (10 of 70)	4.3% (1.5–11.9) (3 of 70)	0.0% (0.0–5.2) (0 of 70)	1.4% (0.3–7.7) (1 of 70)	12.9
Uniqlo	6.7% (2.9–14.7) (5 of 75)	9.3% (4.6–18.0) (7 of 75)	0.0% (0.0–4.9) (0 of 75)	2.7% (0.7–9.2) (2 of 75)	13.3% (7.4–22.8) (10 of 75)	1.3% (0.2–7.2) (1 of 75)	0.0
Set average	17.0%	17.4%	12.0%	3.5%	7.3%	1.9%	4.6

Zara, Aritzia and H&M sit within 1.3 points of each other on price/value share; Uniqlo leads on style/trend (28.1%) and Shein is lowest on both

Brand	Price/value share	Style/trend share	Mention sentences	Net sentiment
Aritzia	27.7% (19.9–37.1)	20.8% (14.0–29.7)	284	+0.412
Zara	27.9% (22.7–33.7)	20.3% (15.8–25.7)	473	+0.265
H&M	26.6% (20.0–34.4)	21.7% (15.7–29.1)	339	+0.329
Shein	20.2% (15.8–25.4)	15.4% (11.5–20.2)	441	+0.202
Uniqlo	24.8% (20.0–30.3)	28.1% (23.1–33.8)	584	+0.435
Old Navy	26.7% (14.2–44.4)	20.0% (9.5–37.3)	113	+0.329
Everlane	50.0% (34.8–65.2)	10.5% (4.2–24.1)	113	+0.134

Shein over-indexes on cheap/disposable, ethical/responsible, unethical/exploitative and under on basic/everyday; Uniqlo over-indexes on basic/everyday and under on trendy/fashion-forward

Brand	Image	z	Observed	Expected	Reading
Shein	basic/everyday	-4.53	3	17.2	distinctive (neutral image)
Shein	cheap/disposable	+3.95	22	11.4	weakness
Shein	ethical/responsible	+4.04	9	3.0	flagged, association not endorsement
Shein	unethical/exploitative	+3.72	6	1.8	weakness
Uniqlo	basic/everyday	+8.90	50	20.5	distinctive (neutral image)
Uniqlo	trendy/fashion-forward	-3.87	0	9.3	weakness

Only 1 cell has enough sentences to place: Uniqlo's basic/everyday image, at 2.5 times the set average with net sentiment +0.62

Brand	Image	n	Share	Index vs set average	Net sentiment	Quadrant
Uniqlo	basic/everyday	50	66.7%	2.54	+0.62	defend

APPENDIX

Sources and credits

Data

- Reddit posts and comments through the Arctic Shift archive, Nov 2025 to Oct 2026 (general subreddits only for cross-brand modules).
- App Store store-level ratings from the iTunes lookup API; Wikipedia monthly page views (English, all-access, user).
- Files: data/metrics.json, data/quotes.json; method in data/README.md. Analysis run 2026-11-02 (UTC); supplementary run 2026-11-02 (UTC).

Credits

- Brief and market context: brief.md, with the citations shown on the market-context page.
- Sentiment: VADER (Hutto and Gilbert, 2014). Formula sources are listed with each formula.
- Charts: Plotly. Formulas: KaTeX. Type: Inter and Playfair Display (Google Fonts, SIL Open Font License). Icons: simple line drawings in the style of Lucide (ISC licence).

THE TEAM

Who made this report

These roles were played by AI agents under keeploop.

Analyst

Analysis and the report draft.

Engineer

Edits to the report.

Auditor

Independent audit of each change.

Tech

Data collection, charts and this report.

Content

Report prose.

QC

Final check of the outputs.

keeploop result: baseline 0.970000, best 1.000000 (+0.030000), audit APPROVED, change KEPT (run/cycle-2/transcript.txt). How this report was made, including the mistakes.